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To the Editorial Board

Journal of Statistical Mechanics: Theory and Experiment

Dear Editors,

Please consider the enclosed manuscript, “Density-gated noise rectification in a Vicsek–Couzin flock: one dense-phase mechanism, additive at matched decorrelation,” for publication in JSTAT as an original research article. We suggest the section *Classical statistical mechanics, equilibrium and non-equilibrium*.

The paper makes a methodological point through a concrete model. Flocking studies routinely compare noise distributions of different shape at matched nominal amplitude η , but that comparison is not neutral: a wrapped α -stable kick of scale η decorrelates a heading at the rate $\Gamma = 1 - \exp(-\eta^\alpha)$, which depends on the tail index as strongly as on the amplitude. Varying the shape at fixed η therefore varies the effective noise as well, and the confound is large enough to manufacture an apparent cooperative effect that survives several independent consistency checks before a matched-decorrelation control dissolves it.

The vehicle is a Vicsek–Couzin flock in which one sigmoid in the local neighbour count gates both the self-propulsion speed and the stability index of the angular noise, making a crowded particle slow and Gaussian-like, an isolated one fast and Cauchy-like. That is deliberately the arrangement most favourable to a synergy, which is what makes a negative answer informative. Compared at each mode’s own near-critical noise the full model appears to gain a super-additive boost, $\Delta_g = +0.45$; under the matched-decorrelation control it falls to $+0.02$, additive within error, while the dense correlation gaps reverse sign. The coupling reduces to a density-gated lowering of the dense-phase effective noise, contingent on a metric kernel.

We have positioned the contribution narrowly, its components being individually well studied. Density-dependent motility with alignment is established, and a density-dependent noise *amplitude* is not new; what has not been done is to make the *shape* of the turning law a function of local density and couple it to a density-dependent speed, a cell the framework of Clusella and Pastor-Satorras admits and then sets aside. In the same spirit we report the finite-size slopes as effective growth rates rather than asymptotic exponents, and the internal falsifications are reported rather than buried.

All code and data are openly available at <https://github.com/yayayou47/two-feedback-vicsek> under the MIT licence, and every figure reproduces bit-for-bit from a single seeded generator. The manuscript is original, is not under consideration elsewhere, and its two authors declare no competing interests; one supplementary-material PDF accompanies it.

Thank you for considering our submission.

Sincerely,



Yaya Youssouf Yaya

Corresponding author, on behalf of both authors

Département de Mathématiques, École Normale Supérieure de N’Djaména, Tchad

yy.y@zig.univ.sn ORCID: 0000-0003-0781-4923